

Passing notes

Passing notes are so called because they pass the harmony of a sequence from one chord to another. They break the rhythmic and harmonic regularity of a series of chords, and add decoration and tension to a phrase.

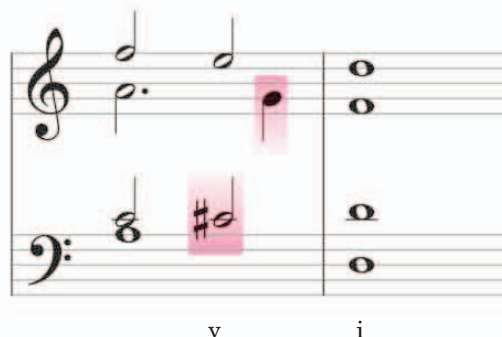
Non-harmony notes

Passing notes and suspensions are known as non-harmony notes because they do not belong to the harmony of a particular chord. They fill in the gaps between the chords, even though other notes may be sounding at the same time. A simple passing-note sequence outline fills in the interval of a third between two notes, moving stepwise between them.



△ **Passing notes in the melody and bass**
The highlighted passing note creates a dissonance. Passing notes can occur in any part of a chordal texture, not just the melody line.

124



125 △ **Passing notes in the harmony**
Here the passing note is in the alto line. Note that the C# in the tenor line creates a dissonance, before falling down to D.

More than one passing note

Two or more passing notes can be used to link the harmony notes, to go chromatically, half step by half step, through the interval of a third, or to link the interval of a fourth.



▽ Chopin's "Étude Op.10, No.2"

Chopin wrote an entire study in which pianists can perfect the smoothness of their passing notes through the chromatic scale in the right hand.